

Source firewall

ASHOKAN INSCRIPTIONS -> contemporary royal voice; command/self-presentation > implementation

ARCHAEOLOGY -> Pataliputra, Taxila, Sanchi, Barabar, coins; context/date before attribution

MEGASTHENES -> lost Indica through Strabo/Arrian/Diodorus/Pliny: double filter

ARTHASHASTRA -> layered prescriptive statecraft; never a direct Mauryan manual

PURANIC + BUDDHIST + JAIN -> dynastic/religious memory; name genre and time gap

WRITE -> claim -> named source/site -> analysis -> qualification

Rise, rulers and chronology

Magadha-Nanda fiscal/riverine/urban base + post-Alexander north-western fluidity

-> Chandragupta coalition, conquest, organisation and legitimacy

c. 324/321 BCE Chandragupta -> c. 297 Bindusara -> c. 268/273-232 Ashoka

accession != consecration; regnal years are firmer than one absolute chronology

Kalinga follows eight completed years after abhisheka; c. 261 BCE is conventional

post-232 rulers -> bounded bridge only; Topic 15 owns full decline

Chandragupta, Seleucus and Bindusara

Nanda overthrow/Chanakya -> later plural traditions; Mudrarakshasa is not contemporary

Sandrokottos/Androkottos -> classical synchronism with post-Alexander world

Seleucus c. 305-303/302 -> settlement + territorial recognition/transfer debate

500 elephants -> classical treaty term; literary figure, not audited inventory

epigamia -> marriage/intermarriage clause uncertain; do not invent a named bride

Bindusara/Amitrochates -> Hellenistic contacts firmer than mapped Deccan conquest

Imperial geography: rule, influence and absence

PATALIPUTRA CORE -> middle Ganga metropolitan concentration

NW -> Taxila, Shahbazgarhi, Mansehra, Kandahar: multilingual frontier/corridor

WEST -> Ujjayini/Girnar; EAST -> Tosali, Dhauri, Jaugada; SOUTH -> Suvarnagiri/edict belt

Chola + Pandya + Keralaputra + Satiyaputra + Tambapanni -> named neighbours/outreach, not provinces

far south and much north-east lack proof of direct Mauryan rule; absence != empty land

FIND-SPOT -> communication/contact; never draw a modern border around edicts

Kingship, provinces and local mediation

KING -> appointment + army + justice + patronage + command, dependent on information
mantriparishad/ministers -> textual reconstruction; inscriptions reveal only parts
kumara/aryaputra + provincial centres -> dynastic delegation, not one universal template
province -> district/field -> town/village -> households, guilds, local elites
Taxila/Ujjayini/Tosali/Suvarnagiri -> cautious node list, not exhaustive schedule
central purpose + regional adaptation + intermediary information gaps

Officers and inscriptional functions

mahamatta -> broad high-official category; specialised portfolios, not one rank

dhamma-mahamatta -> Major Rock Edict V: social/religious/welfare policy, not clergy

pradeshika + rajuka + yukta -> Rock Edict III tours; official 2025 key = district level

rajuka -> populations, justice/welfare; land-measurement link remains suggestive

yukta -> executive/accounting/subordinate contexts; exact hierarchy debated

Rock Edict VI pativedaka reporting -> accessibility ideal + imperial information strategy

Army, espionage and justice

fiscal base -> infantry + cavalry + chariots + elephants + forts/corridors

Megasthenes military/city committees -> later fragments; useful, not audited universal chart

Arthashastra spies/secret agents -> theory of surveillance; corroborate before application

Pillar Edict IV -> rajuka responsibility + uniformity concern + three-day reprieve

death penalty, punishment and forest warning continue after Kalinga

VERDICT -> coercive state constrained by paternal justice, not abolished by dhamma

Revenue, land, irrigation and exchange

agriculture/land/labour -> bhaga + bali + tolls + fines + obligations ->
treasury/army/officials

Rummindei -> local bali exemption + bhaga reduced to one-eighth; not empire-wide rate

Sudarshana -> later Junagadh record: Pushyagupta/Chandragupta + Tushaspha/Ashoka

roads/rivers/security/standards -> facilitate and tax trade

punch-marked coins -> circulation; issuer/date/state monopoly uncertain; kind/barter persist

Arthashastra mines/forests/workshops -> strategic regulation model, not command economy fact

Society, dependence and women

Megasthenes seven groups -> Greek occupation/status scheme, not varna-jati census

Brahmana/Kshatriya prestige + cultivators/merchants/artisans/soldiers/officials -> varied positions

dasa/dasi + bhataka + debt/service -> dependence; translation and prevalence uncertain

2022 Arthashastra PYQ -> answer textual provision first, then prescription/practice caution

Queen Karuvaki -> named elite gift agency; cannot generalise equality

urban-rural flows + patriarchal household + regional/forest difference remain

Ashoka, Kalinga and retained sovereignty

later succession/fratricide stories -> moral biography, not contemporary fact

Minor Rock Edict I -> gradual Buddhist commitment before simple Kalinga-conversion story

Major Rock Edict XIII -> conquest + deportation/death/suffering claims + remorse

Separate Kalinga Edicts -> fairer administration, restraint, confidence-building

dhamma-vijaya preferred -> ethical reorientation of victorious kingship

Kalinga retained + army/punishment/ativika warning -> no full pacifism

Dhamma, welfare and toleration

CONTENT -> parents/elders + servants + Brahmanas/Shramanas + truth + restraint + non-injury

Rock Edict XII -> restrain self-praise/denunciation; listen and grow essentials of all sects

MACHINERY -> dhamma-mahamattas + tours + reports + oral recitation + inscriptions

Rock Edict II -> medical/useful plants/wells horizon for humans and animals

animal policy -> reduction/restriction with exceptions; not total meat/hunting ban

dhamma = Buddhist-rooted public ethic + paternal integration; not state conversion/modern welfare state

Edict classes, scripts, languages and site traps

MINOR ROCK -> personal zeal/name evidence; MAJOR ROCK -> broad policy; PILLAR -> mature governance

SEPARATE KALINGA -> Dhauli/Jaugada; local sequence/omission matters

most -> Prakrit-Brahmi; Shahbazgarhi/Mansehra -> Prakrit-Kharoshthi

Kandahar/north-west -> Greek and Aramaic adaptation, not one literal master translation

Maski/Gujarra -> Ashoka name; Rummindei/Nigali Sagar -> Terai pilgrimage records

TRAP -> site + corpus + script + theme + audience; no site contains a complete universal set

Buddhism, monuments and regional diversity

Bhabru/Bairat + Lumbini + Nigali Sagar + schism edicts -> personal Buddhist patronage/discipline

Third Council + Moggaliputta Tissa + Mahinda/Sanghamitta missions -> later chronicle tradition

Barabar -> Ajivika dedications; Sanchi -> Ashokan core with later stone phases

pillars/capitals -> quarry, transport, polish, royal communication; detailed style -> Art & Culture

Kumrahar/Bulandibagh -> Mauryan-associated urban scale; palace/function labels debated

imperial integration connected regions without erasing local economies, languages or institutions

Historiography, answer route and decline bridge

CENTRALISED MODEL -> court + revenue + army + officers + edicts + strategic works

DIFFERENTIATED MODEL -> distance + ecology + local mediation + multilingual variants + uneven archaeology

SYNTHESIS -> strong metropolitan/corridor capacity; graded direct rule, tribute and negotiated frontiers

governance = information + mobility + extraction + legitimacy; communication also reveals limits

post-Ashoka names vary; Dasharatha cave inscriptions are firmer than full succession lists

ANSWER -> define/source matrix -> rulers/map -> institutions/economy -> Ashoka/dhamma -> debate -> qualified verdict